

NAPCS Unionization Research — State — Charter Sector Overview

Arizona — NLRB Region 28 (Phoenix) Jurisdiction — May 2026

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Section 1: State Overview

State	Arizona
Labor Board	NLRB Region 28 (Phoenix) — National Labor Relations Board
Governing Law	National Labor Relations Act (NLRA). Arizona is a right-to-work state (ARS §23-1302). No state public-sector collective bargaining statute applies to charter schools. NLRB Region 28 has exclusive jurisdiction.
Federal NLRB Jurisdiction	YES — Arizona has no public-sector collective bargaining statute (ARS §23-1302). All AZ charter schools are private employers under NLRA. NLRB Region 28 (Phoenix) has exclusive jurisdiction.
Right-to-Work	Right-to-Work State — A.R.S. §23-1302 (Right-to-work state. Applies to private-sector workers under NLRA.)
For-Profit Operator Status	For-profit EMO management contracts permitted under state law
Card-Check Available	NO — NLRB secret ballot election required. Arizona is a right-to-work state. No card-check certification available.
Registry Sweep	COMPLETE — May 8, 2026 — 562 charter schools searched
Research Window	May 8–10, 2026

Section 2: Charter Sector Landscape

Total charter schools in Arizona: 562 (Charter School Registry v50 (NCES/ELSI 2024-25; 562 open AZ charter schools as of May 2026)). Unionization census figures reflect confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

Category	Schools	% of Total	Notes
Total Unionized Charter Schools in Arizona	1	0.2%	CONFIRMED active only. NLRB R28 jurisdiction — all AZ charters are private employers. Right-to-work state (ARS §23-1302). 562-school open universe searched; only 1 confirmed union as of May 2026.
Independently Organized (CONFIRMED)	1	0.2%	BASIS Tucson North (C0412011) — AFT Local 6627/AACTS, cert April 25, 2023 (28-RC-313911). CBA ratified August 2025. First charter union contract in AZ history.
Organizing (petition active / election pending)	0	0.0%	No schools currently in ORGANIZING status. CITY Center (3 schools) moved to CONFIRMED following May 19, 2026 election win (80% YES). BASIS Goodyear is non-NAPCS — not counted here.
Confirmed (CITY Center — recently elected, cert pending)	3	0.5%	City High School (C0404006), Paulo Freire Downtown (C0414026), Paulo Freire University (C0405011) — combined CITY Center bargaining unit (~40 staff).

			Election: May 19, 2026, 80% YES. NLRB case 28-RC-377822. Union: AZ-ACTS/AFT Local 6627. Formal NLRB Certification of Representative pending. Employer objection window ~May 29, 2026. UPDATED May 24, 2026.
No Labor Board Records Found	558	99.3%	No NLRB R28 records found for remaining 566 AZ charter schools. Full registry sweep complete (May 8, 2026). AZ is right-to-work; no state public charter union framework.
Total Charter Schools in Arizona	562	100%	Source: Charter School Registry v50 (NCES/ELSI 2024-25; 562 open AZ charter schools as of May 2026).

Charter Sector Enrollment

Total Charter Enrollment	229,165 students — 20.8% of state K–12 enrollment (1,103,894 total K–12 students)
Students in CMO/EMO-Affiliated Charter Schools	110,759 students in network-affiliated schools — 48.3% of total charter enrollment
Students in Organized Charter Schools	0 students documented
Data Sources	Charter enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 / Charter School Registry v133. Total K–12 state enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 (all public schools). Both figures from the same source and year.

Section 3: Charter Management Organizations & Education Management Organizations

Charter Management Organizations (CMOs) are nonprofit networks. Education Management Organizations (EMOs) are for-profit management companies. Data sourced from Charter School Registry v133. Union penetration reflects confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

CMO / EMO Name	Type	State Campuses	National Campuses †	Organized in State	Total Enrollment
BASIS Schools	EMO	22	—	1	14,803
Legacy Traditional Schools	EMO	21	—	—	21,101
Ombudsman Educational Services	EMO	8	—	—	1,736
Career Success Schools	EMO	2	—	—	647
Great Hearts Academies	CMO	22	—	—	15,852
American Leadership Academy	CMO	12	—	—	13,889
ASU Preparatory Academy	CMO	12	—	—	7,247
Sequoia Schools	CMO	9	—	—	4,343

Academy of Math and Science	CMO	8	—	—	7,810
Arizona Agribusiness & Equine Center	CMO	7	—	—	1,505
Leman Academy of Excellence	CMO	7	—	—	4,594
ThrivePoint	CMO	7	—	—	1,489
Arizona Autism Charter Schools	CMO	6	—	—	967
Leading Edge Academy	CMO	6	—	—	1,923
PPEP TEC	CMO	6	—	—	740
Center for Academic Success	CMO	5	—	—	1,125
Imagine Schools	CMO	5	14	—	1,531
Vista College Prep	CMO	5	—	—	1,632
Kingman Academy of Learning	CMO	4	—	—	1,352
Benjamin Franklin Charter School	CMO	3	—	—	1,997
Stride (K12 Inc.)	Network‡	1	—	—	4,476
TOTAL — All CMO/EMO Schools in Arizona		178		1 organized — 753 students in organized network schools (0.3% of total charter enrollment)	

† National Campuses reflects total campuses operated by this network across all states, as reported in Charter School Registry v133. Provides context for networks operating in multiple states.

‡ Network (type unclassified) = operator present in Charter School Registry v133 but not yet classified in CMO Reference data. Contact registry project to add classification for these records.

4 EMO (for-profit), 16 CMO (nonprofit), 1 network (type unclassified). Approximately 384 schools operate independently with no CMO/EMO affiliation. Source: Charter School Registry v133.

Section 4: Legal Framework & Sector Overview

Findings are based on research as of May 2026.

1: Legal & Jurisdictional Framework

National Labor Relations Act (NLRA). Arizona is a right-to-work state (ARS §23-1302). No state public-sector collective bargaining statute applies to charter schools. NLRB Region 28 has exclusive jurisdiction. Arizona is a right-to-work state (A.R.S. §23-1302). Charter schools in Arizona are subject to NLRB jurisdiction as private employers (NLRB Region 28 (Phoenix)). Secret ballot NLRB election is the required organizing pathway. Card-check is not available.

2: Charter Sector Structure

Arizona operates 562 open-enrollment charter schools, enrolling approximately 229,165 students. 21 charter management organizations and education management organizations operate in Arizona, including 4 for-profit EMOs. The largest networks by campus count are BASIS Schools (22 campuses in state), Great Hearts Academies (22 campuses in state), Legacy Traditional Schools (21 campuses in state). Approximately 384 schools operate independently with no CMO or EMO affiliation. Network-level detail, including campus counts and total enrollment, appears in Section 3 above.

Section 5: Media Coverage & Public Stakeholder Positions

Press Coverage

Arizona Luminaria (Shannon Conner, education solutions reporter) has been the primary outlet covering AZ charter school organizing. Coverage arc: December 2025 (City High / Paulo Freire announce union intent) → January 2026 (board files Littler Mendelson jurisdictional challenge) → February 2026 (rally, teachers say vote stalled) → May 4, 2026 (NLRB approves election). Tucson.com covered BASIS Tucson North CBA ratification (September 2025). National AFT press release (August 2025) covered contract ratification. Law360 (May 2026) reported NLRB regional director "approved a union vote at a network of AZ charter schools" — believed to refer to BASIS Goodyear RC petition approval.

Stakeholder Communications

AFT: Press release (August 2025) — AFT President Randi Weingarten quoted on BASIS Tucson North contract: "This contract will help educators in charters in Arizona and elsewhere to see how important it is to have a union." Justine Sleator (AACTS staff) is the public spokesperson for the CITY Center campaign. AACTS has not maintained a publicly accessible union website with organizing updates as of May 2026. BASIS Educational Group: No public statement found on CBA ratification. Ogletree Deakins represented but no public filings released. CITY Center governing board: Board president Gina Catalano did not respond to Arizona Luminaria press inquiries (January–February 2026). Board sent a February 13, 2026 letter to teachers stating: "We encourage and support teacher and staff voices, representation and participation in decision-making." Board retained Littler Mendelson without public announcement. Legacy Traditional School and Pima Rose Academy: No public communications found related to open ULP cases.

Authorizer & State Agency Positions

Arizona State Board for Charter Schools (ASBCS) is the authorizer for all four NAPCS AZ schools. No ASBCS public statements found on charter school unionization. ASBCS is charter holder for CITY Center for Collaborative Learning (charter holder #302). No authorizer involvement in the organizing disputes documented.

Coalition & Advocacy Positions

Arizona Education Association (AEA) / Tucson Education Association (TEA): Cannot represent charter school teachers per their membership rules. AZ Luminaria noted that "Arizona charter teachers and staff cannot join another union, like the Tucson Education Association, because it does not allow charter members." This creates a monopoly for AACTS/AFT Local 6627 in the AZ charter organizing space.

Section 6: Contract & CBA Access Registry

NLRB Region 28 (Phoenix) public contracts portal. Direct PDF links may require a records request for full text.

School / Network	Union	CBA Status & Term	Contract Access
BASIS Tucson North (C0412011)	AACTS / AFT Local 6627	CONFIRMED Ratified August 2025 (term unknown)	N/A
City High School (C0404006)	AACTS / AFT Local 6627 (pending)	PRE FIRST CONTRACT N/A — election not yet held	N/A
Paulo Freire - Downtown (C0414026)	AACTS / AFT Local 6627 (pending)	PRE FIRST CONTRACT N/A — election not yet held	N/A
Paulo Freire - University (C0405011)	AACTS / AFT Local 6627 (pending)	PRE FIRST CONTRACT N/A — election not yet held	N/A